

Judging Policy on Category Selection

In your review of the projects in your category, you may come across a project that you believe is in the wrong category. Here we discuss how this situation can arise and what you should do in response.

The Philosophy of ISEF Judging

ISEF is about the students. You should make every effort to judge and score each project to the best of your ability, based on the science and engineering of that project. External factors, such as appropriateness of the category, should not be among your considerations.

If you come across a project that you believe is in the wrong category, this does not change your responsibility as a judge. All judges should take the broadest possible view of every project. You may have an opinion regarding the appropriateness of the project for the category, but that opinion is irrelevant to the quality of the project itself.

ISEF policy is that the finalist is solely responsible for their category selection and advises students to study their category options thoroughly because a poor choice may affect the likelihood of their winning an award.

Is There Always a Single “Right Category”?

No. For most projects, one and only one category makes sense, but many projects involve multiple subjects, and this makes choosing the “right category” difficult. There may be more than one appropriate category, but that does not mean that each is equally appropriate.

For example, a project that uses machine learning to study a particular disease could reasonably belong in several different categories, depending upon which aspect of this description was of most concern to the student. This project might belong in:

- ROBO (Robotics and Intelligent Machines), subcategory MAC (Machine Learning), if the student focused on building the machine and only used the disease as a test bed in which to study the performance of the machine, or
- BMED (Biomedical and Health Sciences), subcategory PAT (Pathophysiology), if the machine was used as a tool to study the disease, or
- TMED (Translational Medical Science), subcategories DIS (Disease Detection and Diagnosis), PRE (Disease Prevention), TRE (Disease Treatment and Therapies), or DRU (Drug Identification and Testing), depending upon which aspect of studying the disease is most relevant.

The point here is that a title or general subject area is insufficient to identify “the right category.” If the student does not follow ISEF’s advice to consider all of the possibilities carefully, then the project may easily end up in a less than optimal category, but this should not change how you evaluate it.

ISEF counsels students to choose the category where judges will ask the questions that they most want to answer. Ideally, these questions were most important in their research. To the extent that students follow this advice, your expertise and the student’s research should match.

Is the Student Trying to “Game the System”?

Probably not.

In local and regional science fairs, some students will place their project in a questionable category because they think that the choice will improve their odds of winning an award. This might be because the chosen category is smaller than others are, and all categories have the same number of awards.¹ Those students in local and regional science fairs are truly “gaming the system.” Many judges have seen this strategy, and therefore have an immediate prejudice against any project that does not fit their notion of the kind of project that belongs in their category.

This strategy cannot work at ISEF because the number of projects in each category determines the number of awards at all levels, First through Fourth. ISEF does not set the number of awards in any category until immediately before the Fair when the project counts in every category are fixed. Therefore, even if judges did give awards completely randomly, no student could improve their odds of winning through strategically choosing a category. Students know this before submitting their projects to ISEF. Consequently, there is no justification for bias against any project solely because judges disagree with the student’s choice of category.

Why Are Some Projects in “the Wrong Category”?

Other than the considerations in the above few paragraphs, there are several possible answers to this question.

- Most often, it is because the student has not followed ISEF’s advice to choose the category where they will meet with judges most knowledgeable about the most important aspect of their work, particularly if the project work involves multiple fields.
- The student may be under a misimpression that they have to compete in the same category from which they qualified at their local/regional fair.
- The student’s research advisor may have misadvised them. This could easily happen if the advisor knows only the titles of the categories, but has not read the explicit definitions *including subcategories* crafted by ISEF.
- Similarly, a teacher, parent, or helpful family friend may have misadvised them.

The point here is that none of these reasons has anything to do with what you are judging. You should therefore *not* add “belongs in category” to your own list of judging criteria.

Should I Say Something to Someone?

No. ISEF has already reviewed obvious categorization problems. Besides, by the time you see the project it is too late to change categories, even if the student were receptive to the idea. Nothing good can come of raising this issue with the student. Mentioning it to them can only cause stress and uncertainty in the student, which runs counter to the spirit of judging at ISEF.

¹ Success of this strategy implicitly relies upon the assumption that award selection is somewhat random. That assumption is rarely valid. At ISEF, it is clearly not.

Similarly, raising the issue in caucus is not constructive because “belongs in category” is not a judging criterion.

The Aspects That I Don’t Understand Are Impressive

Your responsibility as a judge is to evaluate each project fairly. If you are not conversant with an important aspect of the project, you cannot fairly evaluate that aspect, though you should be able to evaluate the balance of the project’s effort.

Importantly, you cannot simply take the word of the student that his/her work is outstanding, any more than you would take the word of a student whose project you do fully understand. When you evaluate other projects that are within your expertise, *those students have to earn your trust* by answering your critical questions. It would be unfair to those students if you gave another project a high score, without it similarly earning your trust through a critical interview.

Therefore, you should not give any project a high score that it has not earned through your expert evaluation, nor should you give it a low score simply because you do not understand it.

So What Should I Do?

If you think that a project is in the wrong category, and consequently cannot understand important aspects of that project, please refer to Document *D: How to Interview* in section II of the *Judge Information Board*, especially the section on this issue. Base your interview score on what you *do* understand of the project. You can also confer with your category co-chair for guidance. Later, while caucusing with the other judges in your category to determine all awards, you may come to a better understanding of the project through listening to the comments of other judges who did understand those aspects of the project that you did not. Your voting on awards should then reflect your more nuanced appreciation of each project.

Points of Emphasis

1. Being in the right or wrong category is not a criterion of judging. There are many innocent reasons why a project may have ended up in an inappropriate category.
2. Do not give the project a high interview score simply because the work appears impressive. Similarly, do not give a low score simply because you do not understand it.
3. When scoring your interview, evaluate what you *do* understand about the project. During caucusing for awards, your understanding may change based upon comments by other more knowledgeable judges.